

Q What checkups will my baby have when I leave the hospital, and in the early weeks?

You'll visit your baby's new pediatrician at his office during the first few days that your baby goes home.

During the appointment, your pediatrician will want to know how feeding is progressing, especially if you are breast-feeding. He'll also examine all aspects of your baby's health and well-being at this first appointment, including the hearing, vision, and hip-joint tests that she had at the hospital. Pediatricians provide an invaluable resource for help and advice and are there to help you in this early period. If you need

help to establish breast-feeding, the pediatrician is an excellent person to ask for help. If you have questions about your baby's sleeping patterns and whether she's sleeping too much or too little between feedings, your pediatrician will have advice. The doctor will also weigh

your baby. Your baby will be weighed at regular intervals throughout her first year of life. The pediatrician will also plot your baby's height, weight, and head circumference on charts, allowing for growth patterns to be observed over a period of time.



Weigh in Your pediatrician will weigh your baby many times over the course of her first year of life.

The average newborn weight is 7 lb 8 oz (3.4 kg) for boys and 7 lb 4 oz (3.3 kg) for girls. It is normal for babies to lose some of their birth weight in the first week and then regain it.

Q The doctor said she will do a heel-prick test on my baby in the first week. What exactly is it?

This quick procedure, also known as the "blood spot" or Guthrie test, checks for a number of conditions. This test is not compulsory, but it is recommended since the benefits of early screening are enormous. Early treatment can improve the health of your baby and prevent severe disability. You should be given information about this test and the diseases it screens for in advance so you can make an informed decision for your baby.

The test is done two or three days after the birth. The doctor will prick your baby's heel to collect a blood sample on a card, which is then sent off for analysis. Your baby may feel a little discomfort during this test, which can be upsetting for parents, too. Holding and cuddling your baby and feeding him while the test is being done is thought to minimize any discomfort your baby feels. The heel-prick

test screens for nine conditions: the genetic blood disorder sickle-cell disease; cystic fibrosis, an inherited condition; congenital hypothyroidism, a condition that affects growth and mental development; and six inherited metabolic diseases such as MCADD and phenylketonuria (PKU).

You should receive the results by the time your baby is about eight weeks old. If any of the screens are positive, it means your baby is more likely to have one of these conditions and he will be referred for further testing.

Q My baby is hardly gaining weight. Should I be worried?

It's easy to worry if you think your baby isn't piling on the pounds. Watching a baby's weight steadily creep up is a reassuring sign for parents that they are getting it right. However, some babies are just naturally slower at gaining weight. If your baby is happy, alert, responsive,

and reaching milestones, he is probably fine. If you feel uneasy, talk to your pediatrician who can check your baby's growth chart. If your baby has gone down two percentiles, or has dropped below the third percentile for growth, more checks and investigations may be recommended.

A failure to gain weight usually happens when a baby isn't getting the calories he needs, or his body isn't absorbing or using nutrients properly. There is often a simple explanation. If your baby has been sick, he may have lost weight and it can take a couple of weeks for his feeding to get back on track. Alternatively, he may not be latching on (see pp.268-69) properly and this can affect his milk intake. If this is the case, seek guidance from your doctor or a breast-feeding consultant.

If your baby is formula fed, make sure the bottle is made up with the right ratio of powder to water so that he gets the nutrients he needs to grow and thrive. Occasionally, slow weight gain is due to a milk intolerance or allergy, reflux, or, more rarely, a medical condition.